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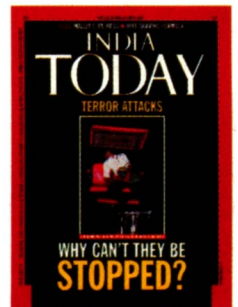
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When does a nation say enough is enough? If you are India, it seems like never in spite of 1,120 deaths from 69 Islamic terrorist attacks since 2000. Last week saw 54 deaths in blasts on consecutive days in Bangalore and Ahmedabad. A day later, 28 bombs were defused in Surat.

In the last 10 years, there have been bomb attacks in Mumbai, Coimbatore, Srinagar, Ahmedabad, Delhi, Varanasi, Hyderabad, Bangalore, Jaipur, more than once in some cities. In 2007, the United States' National Institute of Counter Terrorism calculated that between January 2004 and March 2007, the death toll in India from all terrorist attacks was 3,674, second only to Iraq during the same period. On the terrorist death charts, we are second to a country which has a civil war on its hands and has an occupying army. This is incredible.

What has been most frustrating in these last few days is the sameness of the events. Bombs go off, lives are lost, a home minister mouths a few platitudes, and a few days later, everyone gets on with their lives exactly as they did before. Terrorists seemed to attack at will and the real culprits are never caught. No place is safe in India.

Look at what America did after 9/11. Despite being one of the world's most liberal democracies where you can burn the national flag or wear it as underwear, they introduced the Patriot Act which allows detention, tapping of phone conversations and monitoring emails and bank accounts in the interests of the State. The Department of Homeland Security was set up to co-ordinate the work of all intelligence agencies. Although they are the prime target for terrorists, the US has had no terrorist attack since 9/11.



Our May 2008 cover

In India, like in other spheres, we go through the ritual of dealing with terrorists but actually do nothing substantive. We have repealed acts like POTA which were meant to tackle terrorism through pre-emptive arrests. Our security agencies do not work in a co-ordinated manner to make full use of the intelligence. Law enforcement is not funded enough for adequate policing and developing intelligence networks. There is no sense of purpose conveyed to citizens at large to get their co-operation in preventing such attacks.

Our cover package this week is a comprehensive look at the Indian state's response to terror, or more aptly the lack of it. We have on-the-spot reports as well as an analysis of the radicalisation of the Indian Muslim and how and why the moderates are losing the battle. Seasoned journalist M.J. Akbar and Islamic terror expert Charles Allen have also written special guest columns in the package.

As we near the 61st anniversary of Independence, India appears still enslaved by timidity when it comes down to tackling terror. It is time to say enough is enough and declare zero tolerance for terrorism. Otherwise, the "Incredible India" story is turning into "Impotent India".

Aroon Purie
(Aroon Purie)